1 DS Capstone Project Intro

1.1 Abstract

My project is the assembling and querying of a low-resource corpus of texts in Tiriki. Tiriki is part of the Luhya language group, a subfamily of the Bantu language family. Tiriki is spoken in western Kenya by around 200,000 speakers.

1.2 Introduction

The corpus is composed of nearly 300 pieces of oral literature that have been recorded, spliced, transcribed, translated, and glossed. This extensive, painstaking work has been conducted over several years by Micheal JK Diercks, Kelvin Alulu, and many Pomona LGCS students including myself. The recording and translating was done primarily by Kelvin Alulu, our language consultant, a native Tiriki speaker based in Nairobi, Kenya. His knowledge has been invaluable to past and current research on this language.

1.2.1 Motivation:

Tiriki is a low-resource language, meaning there are very few publicly accessible digitized texts in Tiriki. Of the few resources available in Tiriki, many are described as being written "in Luhya", which is misleading as multiple Luhya languages are not mutually intelligible.

Over the summer of 2026, a group of student researchers[1] worked with Diercks and Alulu to meticulously review and compile a subset of these stories into a publishable book. The goal of this research project was to create an open-source resource of Tiriki literature. While final checks and publishing steps of this project are still in-progress, that project inspired and built the foundation for this one.

[1] Clarisse Koo, Silas Mihm, Rowan Norenberg, Fiona Portmore, Leo Sampsell-Jones

1.2.2 Ethics:

Every story in this corpus was knowingly recorded by a researcher. The many individuals who told us their stories did so willingly and enthusiastically, with knowledge of how the recordings would be used in the future. The speakers are accredited for each story that we recorded.

Our aim for all Tiriki-related projects to be open-source and widely available is with the intention of providing linguistic resources to the community.

This project uses texts that were collected and analysed under IRB Case number: #05222017MD-FL. The greatest possible harm that could come to the humans involved in this project and related projects is boredom.

1.2.3 Questions

Once the corpus is assembled, I intend to query the corpus with a number of questions. Some questions I am interested in include (but are not limited to) the following:

(1) How frequently is one negation marker used over another (eg mba versus tawe)? Is there a pattern of occurrence?

(2) How frequently are verbs, when in agreement with a non-human animate subject, marked with the human subject marker rather than the expected subject marker[2]?

(3) How frequently does locative inversion occur? Is there a preference for disjoint or repeated constructions where locative inversion does occur?

[2] Occasionally, where we would expect to see a class 5 subject marker, a class 1 subject marker appears instead.

a. *Ne navoola, "vaana vovo vavele varhanu."*
ne n-**a**-vool-a va-aana vovo va-v-el-e va-rhanu
DPART.and FOC-**1SM**-say-FV 2-children 2.POSS.PRON.2SG 2SM-be-APPL-PFV 2-five
'And it said, "You have five children."'

a. *Ne nilivoola, "vaana vovo vavele varhanu."*
ne ni-**li**-vool-a va-aana vovo va-v-el-e va-rhanu
DPART.and FOC-**5SM**-say-FV 2-children 2.POSS.PRON.2SG 2SM-be-APPL-PFV 2-five
'And it said, "You have five children."'

Literature review and a brief summary of my findings pending. The example in the introduction will be moved to my Results section in the future, but I'm including it here for now for my own reference. Organization structure also extremely subject to change.